ROMAN FORT

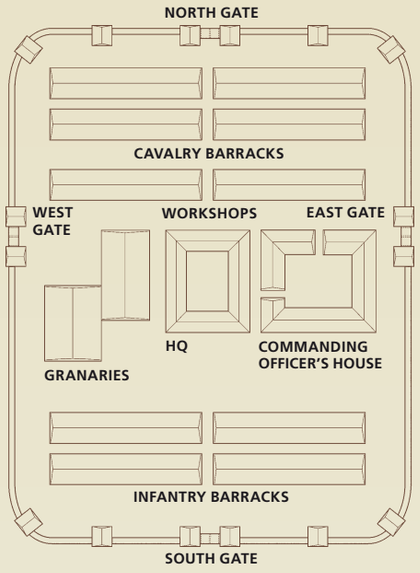
The Romans were the greatest experts in fortification in the Ancient World. When on campaign, a legion would construct a fortified camp, surrounded by a rampart and ditch, at every stop. Whereas fighting might often be left to less well-trained auxiliaries, building work was always the job of legionaries. They would have built the fort shown here at Arbeia in northern England, although it subsequently housed auxiliary troops.

Permanent forts and fortresses, like this one that has been reconstructed at Arbeia, were built of stone rather than the wood used for temporary camps. They acted as barracks, supply depots, and administrative headquarters to maintain Rome's military presence in potentially hostile territory. In addition to their military tasks, educated soldiers might be assigned to clerical duties, keeping the written records required by Roman bureaucracy. Outposts of Roman civilization, they made no concessions to local climate or cultures, displaying similar features throughout the empire. Living conditions were cramped and basic, but with their heated bathhouses and latrines cleaned by running water, the forts had a standard of hygiene far superior to any of the quarters provided for the armies that fought almost 2,000 years later in the Crimean War.

Settlements of local civilians grew up around forts and fortresses to service the Roman troops and many modern-day towns and cities trace their origins back to a Roman military base.



Garrisoning the fort
Barrack life would have been familiar to any soldier in a modern regular army. There was morning parade, drill, guard and patrol duties, training exercises, kit to maintain, and latrines to clean.



Layout of a Roman fort
Arbeia was a small fort housing about 600 men. Legionary fortresses, housing 5,000, were much larger, but had a similar layout with barracks for cavalry and infantry, workshops, granaries, and a headquarters building.

> "WHAT OTHERS WOULD HAVE SPREAD OVER SEVERAL DAYS TOOK YOU ONLY ONE TO FINISH: YOU HAVE BUILT A WALL ... IN NOT MUCH MORE TIME THAN IS REQUIRED FOR A TURF RAMPART."
>
> **EMPEROR HADRIAN** TO TROOPS AT LAMBAESIS IN MODERN ALGERIA



Building a fort
Legionaries on the Dacian campaign (101–102 CE) build a stone fort. They are working in full armour in case of a surprise enemy raid.



Gatehouse battlements
The plaque states that the fort was built by Legio VI Victrix under Sextus Calpurnius Agricola, governor of Britain c.163–166 CE.



Doorway
The solid walls and doors of the fort would have kept out the tribal fighters who might carry out raids in Roman-occupied Britain.